smell of sweat. That's perhaps where she learnt how to stand her ground in a male-dominated arena. Through the course of five months, Malik and company have seen their protest being constantly undermined: from being dismissed as a tussle between Thakurs and Jats and later between Haryana and UP to control the WFI to being called stooges of the Congress to a conspiracy hatched by one family (read the Phogats). "These are all tactics to try and deviate from the real issue," says Malik (see *'Others tried to speak out...'*). "The main intent of the protest was that the allegations made against Brij Bhushan be investigated and that the WFI be run by officials who keep the sport clean and take it forward and that there's no exploitation of girls and women."

THE BAHUBALI OF UP

In the 12 years that Singh reigned supreme at the WFI, he allegedly maintained an iron grip on the organisation and wielded all-pervasive influence. Other posts in the body were occupied by members of his family—son Karan

Congress MP Deepender Hooda says even if Singh isn't contesting the WFI election, he can make anybody president. It has become his "benami property"

was vice-president, sons-in-law Aditya Pratap and Vishal Singh were WFI joint secretary and president of the Bihar Wrestling Association, respectively. As head of WFI's selection committee and the athletes' grievance panel as well, he ensured all athletes had to approach him for everything. For wrestlers, this often entailed going to his official residence in the national capital on 21, Ashoka Road, which, curiously, also doubled up as the WFI office. It is here that at least two of the accusers say they were sexually harassed.

A wrestler since his school days, Singh had been organising wrestling events in Gonda since the start of his political career. "Junior and national championships were organised under his watch multiple times," reveals a close aide. "Before mat wrestling came into vogue, he used to hold dangals at his own expense." In 2009, when the BJP's fortunes started waning, Singh switched sides to the Samajwadi Party and won the Lok Sabha election that year. Sources close to him claim that SP founder Mulayam Singh Yadav

INTERVIEW | ANURAG THAKUR

'WE BELIEVE IN A TRANSPARENT, TIMELY PROBE'

As the *Union minister of sports, youth affairs and information & broadcasting,* **Anurag Thakur** has the difficult task of suitably addressing the allegations of sexual harassment by award-winning female wrestlers against Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) president Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh while ensuring it does not scar the sport itself. Shortly after assuring the wrestlers that the Delhi Police will file a chargesheet by June 15, Thakur spoke to *Group Editorial Director* **Raj Chengappa** about the actions the Modi government has taken so far on the issue. Excerpts:

Q. Beginning January, the wrestlers have been protesting against alleged sexual harassment by WFI chief Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh. Why has the issue been dragging on for so long? Why did they have to come out to the streets to protest?

The matter is already under investigation and the government has taken the steps required from day one. First, by my meeting with the protesting athletes on January 19, a day after they started their protest. Second, by forming the [oversight] committee headed by Mary Kom soon after. Third, after getting the report, we asked the IOA (Indian Olympic Association) to set up an ad hoc committee in place of the current one to run day-to-day operations and hold transparent elections for the new committee to run WFI. Fourth, we have submitted the (Mary Kom) committee report to Delhi Police for further investigation, after which they have filed the FIR and investigations are on.

Q. But couldn't the action have been taken far sooner?

Many of the allegations are about something that hap-